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religion and spirituality

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Histories of sexuality have tended to recapitulate existing stories of modernity, one of which is the apparently increasing secularization of the world. Our ideas of sexuality appear to follow the same pattern as the decline of religion. Until the nineteenth century, so the story goes, sexuality was dominated by religious terms of understanding, but these have been gradually replaced by legal, medical and psychological models of normality and pathology. The history of sexuality appears to run from sin to crime to sickness: from the religious to therapeutic. Traditionally, historians posited a decisive break between these modes of knowledge, but in many ways they are more analogous than separate.¹

Michel Foucault argued in the *History of Sexuality* that religious confession – the revelation of the sins and hidden truths of the self to a father confessor – has been at the centre of Western culture in various forms since the middle ages and that this process also informed modernity. Indeed, he suggested that the agencies which dominate modern life perform an analogous function to religion by forcing a similar kind of confession from secular subjects. Psychiatry, psychoanalysis, consumerism, law, medicine, the family, schools and welfare systems all demand the compulsory ‘confession’ of the details of selfhood, including sexuality. ‘One confesses’, Foucault observed, ‘in public and private, to one’s parents, one’s educators, one’s doctor, to those one loves.’² The ‘truth’ of the self, once the object of solely religious investigation, is thereby demanded at every turn. As Foucault suggests, the historical importance of a religious inheritance to this process of self-making, in which personal experience and sexual desire becomes the bedrock of selfhood and identity, cannot be overestimated.

Ironically though, Foucault's followers have tended to concentrate on the formation of identity via medical and legal sources such as sexology and psychiatry. In this context, a focus on the importance of religion and spirituality acts as an antidote to those histories that concentrate on medicine, the state and the law as chief determinants of sexual identity. Including religion in these histories allows us to do three related things. Firstly, we can show how religion was frequently the location for the expression of unconventional sexuality. Secondly, we can see how early scientific efforts to understand the psychology of sex were informed by spiritual matters. We can therefore see the rise of psychology and psychiatry as intimately linked to non-scientific discourses like spiritualism. Thirdly, we can see how vastly important spiritual and religious matters were in the making of modern science, literature, and culture. This focus therefore allows us to reshape the history of modernity not as a simple story of secularization which is shaped by the death of religion, but one that is informed by a dialogue between the secular and the spiritual.

Where studies of Western sexuality and spirituality intersect, there have been two principal approaches. The first of these deals with the making of individual or collective identity, and the second, derived more from intellectual history, places religion and sexuality at the heart of certain influential cultural trends. A large part of this historiography of personal identity has examined the extent to which religion and spirituality provided a congenial location for the expression of unconventional sexuality, both homosexual and heterosexual. More recently, however, normative heterosexuality has also come under sustained and specific investigation, with the result that spirituality has been located at the heart of the Victorian marriage, as a key ingredient of sexual intimacy. In fact, when speaking of the various intimacies, sexual or otherwise, of the Victorians, it is impossible to understand them without reference to a religious or spiritual context. As well as using the intersection of religion, spirituality and sexuality to understand personal identity and intimacy, historians have also placed this trinity at the heart of important social and cultural trends such as religious revivals, socialism, state formation, spiritualism, and the making of modern Christianity.

Aside from the influence of this investigative technique, religious thought and practice has had an enormous influence on secular institutions and morals, especially since the religious revivals which began in America and Britain in the late eighteenth century and lasted – at least in America – until the 1850s. Religion is therefore now taken much more seriously by historians than it used to be. Whereas in the

1980s religious belief tended to be dismissed as the ideological window dressing for genuine class interest, especially on the part of the middle class, historians now accept that religion informed a diverse collection of secular processes such as state formation, social policy, public health and the law which collectively have had an enormous influence on morality, the social organization of desire, perceptions and practices of sexuality, gender, and the family.

One of the key influences on this kind of social thought and on the perception of sexuality in the nineteenth century was a British clergyman and early sociologist, the Rev. Thomas Malthus. Malthus highlighted what, to him, was the central contradiction of the age: sexual desire was necessary, pleasant and central to human happiness and social being, yet excessive sex – and hence reproduction – could lead to social disaster. Human reproduction, Malthus argued, was likely to outstrip food supply in the long run. Early marriages – and hence more children – thus must be avoided. Catherine Gallagher has pointed out that Malthus' work therefore sets out the central dilemma of the age: sexual passion and the body were universally regarded as good when properly expressed in a prudent marriage, but the misuse of the body might lead to immorality, improvident early marriages, unchecked population increase and social collapse. This simultaneous valuation and problematization of the body was reproduced in a great variety of nineteenth-century discourses in Britain, America and Europe. Partly as a consequence of Malthusian thought, the 'appropriate' use of sexuality became one of the principal themes of nineteenth-century Western culture.

In a post-Malthusian world, in which moral and social certainties were rent asunder by social and political change, various solutions were offered to the problem of sex. One of these was to lay stress on the spiritual content of desire, which redeemed it from the animal, the lustful and the merely physical. Another solution was to try and regulate desire and reproduction according to strict rules based on rationality and the Malthusian dilemma. These features are evident across Anglo-American culture, but were developed most fully amongst those reformers and social leaders who were trying to remake the world. Such trends are most obvious among religious communarians and the emerging middle classes of the early nineteenth century. In particular, the application of spirituality to sexuality was a feature of the religious revivals and consequent communitarian experiments which took place in the US before 1850, especially the northeastern states. It became easier to start society – and sex – anew in the small communities of like believers which were a feature of American revivalism on the western fringes of settlement

in the early nineteenth century. These groups, as well as reforming property so that it was held in common, also faced the difficulty of how to perpetuate their communities. This led them to various experiments in restricting and organizing courtship, sex and reproduction.

One branch of communitarianism tried to banish sex altogether. These were the Shakers, a Quaker sect whose origins lay in northern Britain in the 1780s. They were led by Ann Lee, an English woman who was convinced that she was a prophet, the 'woman clothed with the sun' mentioned in Revelations, and a second, risen Christ. Taking inspiration from a New Testament passage in which Jesus praises the unique sanctity of the unmarried, the Shakers banned all sexual relations in their communities and sought to sublimate sexual energy through energetic rituals such as dancing. Similarly, the 'Perfectionists', who settled in Oneida, New York, took inspiration from the same biblical passage, although they interpreted it to mean that marriage and permanent sexual unions with one person – what they called 'special love' – should be prevented. In their place, the Perfectionists – so called because they claimed to have attained a kind of inner spiritual perfection – instituted a system of partner swapping, or 'complex marriage', which lasted from 1848, when Oneida was founded, until 1879, when the practice was partially abandoned.

In the view of the Perfectionist leader, John Humphrey Noyes, and of European communitarians like Robert Owen and Charles Fourier, marriage was the source of human selfishness, not to mention a system of gender subordination bordering on slavery. While Owen and his followers in Britain tried to abandon marriage and replace it with a relatively unregulated 'free love', Perfectionist complex marriage involved a complicated system of rules governing sexual relations and intimacy between the sexes. These regulations – partly inspired by Malthus' dire predictions about population – were bolstered by incessant debate on what emotional relationships were permissible within the community. Deep attachment to one individual, or 'special love', was discouraged in order to foster allegiance to the larger 'family' of the community itself. Regulation extended to questions of sexual practice. In particular, men were required to practise 'male continence'. This meant not ejaculating during sex, largely as a means of birth control, but also in order to free women from the onerous task of childbearing and allow them to participate more fully in the work of the community.

These practices were regarded by critics of communitarians as an encouragement to sexual licence, but, as Lawrence Foster has explained, part of the popularity of Shakerism, Perfectionism and of Mormonism – which introduced marriage reform in the shape of polygamy in the

1840s – was that these groups promised a solution to the difficulties of frontier life, one of which was the widespread breakdown of conventional marriage. Foster suggests that the problems associated with economic expansion, social mobility and competing value systems in areas of westward growth had made it impossible to maintain conventional bourgeois marital ideals and practices. The Shakers, Perfectionists and Mormons were, he argues, ‘only the tip of an iceberg of dissatisfaction with prevailing marriage, family, and sex roles’. He notes that a widespread practice in disrupted communities on the fringes of westward expansion was ‘spiritual wifery’, a vague term which at best suggested ‘rationalised infidelity’.³ Polygamy, complex marriage, celibacy and free love were therefore concerted attempts to reinforce and rethink marriage and sexual intimacy in the face of social upheaval and the breakdown of conventional morals.

Sexuality was at the centre of religious revivals and communitarian experiments and was hedged about by complex rules and rituals. As such, the form taken by millennial religion on both sides of the Atlantic would seem to bear out Gallagher’s point about the problematic centrality of the body and sexuality to early nineteenth-century thought. Another area in which sexuality was simultaneously valued and problematic was in the formation of the middle class. Middle-class identity, forming in Britain and urban America from the 1830s onwards, was initially predicated on superior morals and religious, usually evangelical, purity. Historians have identified the emergence of separate spheres (public for men, private for women) as a key component of this class identity, an idea which also placed great stress on the sanctity of home and on the purity and sexual passivity of middle-class women. The polar opposite of such purity and morality was an unrestrained sexuality. While Nancy Cott and others have argued that sexual and moral purity was embraced as a source of power for middle-class women in America, abundant evidence exists of the passionate sex lives of some women. Peter Gay, for instance, uncovered in the 1970s the intimate diary of one New England woman, Emily Dickinson’s friend and editor Mabel Loomis Todd. Despite coming from the very stern Puritan tradition which produced evangelical revivals on both sides of the Atlantic, and living at the heart of haute bourgeois culture, Todd’s sex life was passionate, frequent, guiltless and satisfying. Such women therefore faced what seems to us like a contradiction in their very self-image. They addressed the central problem in marriage of how to admit the centrality and pleasure of legitimate sexuality without allowing that sexuality to descend into an immoral sensuality.⁴

As Steven Seidman has pointed out, the way to redeem sexuality, solve the dilemma posed by Malthus, and to ensure that sex did not damage the soul by becoming a mere sensual indulgence, was by insisting on its spiritual nature. Marriage, therefore, became a species of spiritual love, primarily a communion of souls rather than bodies. According to one American writer of the mid-century, marriage was constituted by a 'perfect oneness of feeling and confluence of soul', by 'the complete solution of every feeling and faculty of each with every feeling and faculty of the other, and [by] longing for its attendant spiritual communion'.⁵

According to Seidman, sexuality was in this way 'de-eroticised', divorced from carnal impulses, and rendered safe through its confinement to heterosexual, spiritual marriage.⁶ Spiritual love of this kind was a very common presence in the nineteenth century, in both Britain and America, and did not only sanction sexual desire within marriage. Intense, passionate friendships between men and between women were also characterized by a similar kind of pure, spiritual communion. However, although these romantic friendships were loving, they were not necessarily sexual in the twenty-first-century meaning of that term.

Jonathan Katz argues that a religious understanding of the separation between spiritual and physical was what allowed these friendships to be so intense. Physical and spiritual love were two very different things, and in most circumstances were not allowed to be confused. Donald Yacovone, in a study of the anti-slavery movement in America, argues that spiritual forms of love were inherently Christian. Abolitionism on both sides of the Atlantic was cemented as a movement by a Christian love, or *agapé*, which imitated God's love for his children and sought to repair the damage wrought by the Fall. Similarly, the Abolitionists looked to the early Christian church as their model of community, and thought of themselves as apostles in the same way. These religious associations allowed some Abolitionists to say openly that they 'sometimes felt really in love' with their intimate friends without feeling that this implied an 'unnatural' or 'morbid' physical attraction.⁷ In a similar way, Lillian Faderman has suggested that romantic friendships between women were characteristic of Western societies in the nineteenth century, and were legitimate and encouraged. Faderman suggested, famously, that the homosocial nature of life at the time, and the pervasive idea that female sexuality was inherently passive, created a space in which intense, usually chaste relationships between women became the norm. The nineteenth century, then, was in some ways a golden age of same-sex love.

Were these friendships ever sexual? Earlier historians, writing at a time when any hint of same-sex desire might be discreditable, usually

took a defensive line on this question. The biographers of some key nineteenth-century figures who experienced these friendships such as Walt Whitman, Abraham Lincoln or William Lloyd Garrison, were keen to exonerate their heroes of any taint of homosexuality.⁸ Later writers, more from concern over accuracy than any disdain of homosexuality, also caution against 'mistaking the language of religious ecstasy... or agapé, for homoeroticism or outright "homosexuality"'.⁹ Since no language of sexual identity based around the categories of homosexual/heterosexual existed for much of the nineteenth century, it is anachronistic to suggest that romantic friends be subsumed within these categories.

While this is a useful principle to observe, it would be wrong not to recognize that romantic friendship did have a physical component, but perhaps not in a way which connects these relationships to the modern idea of 'sexual identity'. Yacovone, for instance, admits that physical intimacy, such as kisses of greeting, was at the heart of Abolitionist culture. Similarly, Lillian Faderman's thesis that all spiritual friendships between women were chaste has been substantially revised in the light of Anne Lister's diaries. These journals, compiled in the 1820s and 1830s in the north of England, show a young, aristocratic woman enjoying a spirited sex life with a variety of female lovers, all of whom presumably appeared to the outside world as her (chaste) friends.¹⁰ Similarly, Katz shows that as the nineteenth century progressed, many men tried to assemble a language of homoerotic love out of the tradition of spiritual friendship, thereby blurring the lines between them. Also, as Seidman shows, the spiritual could in some circumstances be the vehicle for physical love. In addition, other writers have argued that the tradition of chivalry, which was revived in the nineteenth century, always contained a sexually ambiguous element, especially in the hands of particular poets such as Gerard Manley Hopkins.¹¹

The question of whether spiritual intimacy and religious dissidence was actually hiding physical homosexual relationships has been at the centre of one of the major controversies of nineteenth-century British religious history. This controversy, which revolves around the question of whether leading figures in the Anglican (Episcopalian) church were homosexual, is not merely of academic interest at a time when modern Anglicanism worldwide is seriously divided over its attitude to gay priests. This debate has centred on the Oxford Movement, a reform group within the early Victorian Anglican church which attained its strongest influence in the period c.1830–60. The Oxford Movement, also known as the Tractarians from their practice of publishing controversial religious tracts, had many different facets. Firstly, the Tractarians wanted to effect a rapprochement

between the Protestant Anglican church and the Catholic church from which it separated at the Reformation. To this end they argued that, with some modifications, the Anglican church could maintain its identity, but also resume its place as a branch of the one, true church. Their proposed reforms centred on ritual, into which they incorporated particular high church practices normally associated with Catholic liturgy such as rich ornamentation, elaborate vestments, Latin mass, decorated altars, celibacy and monasticism. In addition, they continually stressed the common historical inheritance of both the Protestant and Catholic churches and revived the ostensibly Catholic practice of writing and celebrating lives of the saints, a genre associated with the early, Catholic, church.

To their low-church critics, the Tractarians seemed to be diluting Protestantism to the point where it ceased to exist and instead became a form of Catholicism. Although these arguments might now appear arcane, at the time they went right to the heart of national identity. The Protestant, Anglican church was the established church of Britain, and as such maintained strong links with the state. In the early nineteenth century, the link between church and state was frequently held to be a vital pillar of the constitution, especially by conservatives. It was feared that any weakening of the Protestant church might therefore have extensive political ramifications at a time when other major constitutional changes, such as the extension of the franchise, were being made. Moreover, Catholicism was simply un-English, being associated with foreign despotisms which as recently as 1745 had tried to overthrow the English crown by encouraging internal rebellion, and with Irish immigrants who were commonly portrayed as feckless, undisciplined and rebellious.

The most famous attack on the Tractarians came from within the Church of England. In 1851, Charles Kingsley, a mainstream Anglican clergyman, denounced the Oxford Movement, and especially its leader John Henry Newman, in terms which seemed to hint that the Tractarians' deviance was not only religious, but transgressed ideals of manliness and perhaps even sexuality. 'In all that school', Kingsley wrote, 'there is an element of foppery... a fastidious, maundering, die-away effeminacy, which is mistaken for purity and refinement.'¹² David Hilliard has read Kingsley's attack on Tractarian effeminacy as 'the usual nineteenth-century caricature of male homosexuality', and as such, a denunciation of the barely hidden sexual deviance of the entire Anglo-Catholic movement.¹³ In addition, Hilliard suggests that the movement as a whole, with its emphasis on transcendent purity, spiritual friendship and lush ritual, provided a refuge for homosexual men in an otherwise hostile culture. Celibacy in particular appealed to young men unable to recognize or

express their sexual feelings, and who instead devoted themselves to a life of purity and virginity 'in the company of like-minded friends, as a religiously-sanctioned alternative to marriage'.¹⁴ Hilliard is not alone in noticing a correspondence between homosexuality and high-church practice. Ellis Hanson has noted a similar affinity between Catholicism, *fin de siècle* decadence and homoerotic aestheticism.¹⁵

It is certainly the case that some of the leading figures of the Oxford Movement developed intense and loving friendships. Newman, for instance, insisted on being buried in the same grave as his constant companion Ambrose St John, while the Oxford don Frederick Faber wrote many effusive poems to his male friends. In addition, the Oxford Movement led to the establishment of numerous brotherhoods and Tractarian theological colleges, such as Newman's at Cuddesdon near Oxford. Hilliard suggests that the atmosphere of male brotherhood, along with the exaltation of celibate purity may have been 'especially attractive to homosexually-inclined young men'.¹⁶ Moreover, Christian brotherhoods were dogged by actual homosexual scandals. The establishment of the self-styled Father Ignatius (real name John Lyne) in Norfolk aroused particular suspicion when a Norwich newspaper published a love letter written by the choirmaster to a boy. In addition to this kind of scandal, the liturgy, dress and general atmosphere of the Oxford Movement was thought transgressive of particular gender ideals. In particular, the sensual rituals of Tractarian churches were thought at the time to attract 'sentimental ladies and womanish men-youths of a lachrymose turn of mind'.¹⁷

Although some of the late-Victorian historians of the Oxford Movement remarked on the womanly nature of its leaders, the possibility of their homosexuality was first raised by Geoffrey Faber's *Oxford Apostles*, published in 1933, a book which subjected Tractarian leaders to posthumous psychoanalysis. Faber argued that the celibacy of Newman and his Oxford associate Hurrell Froude, a spiritually intense young man whose early death turned him into a combination of saint and martyr for the movement, probably had a homosexual origin. Moreover, Froude's private journal, discovered by his friends after his death, is full of tortured self-reproach about painful emotions, dangerous friendships, and 'thoughts which... are too shocking even to name'. Faber concluded that Froude's self-torture was 'the unmistakable language of conflict with sexual temptation', a battle which was resolved through the idealization of pure, virginal, Christian love.¹⁸

In spite of this evidence there are many problems with trying to identify 'homosexuals', in the modern sense of the term, in the Oxford

Movement. As Katz and others have suggested, these terms of sexual identity are anachronistic in the extreme when applied to Victorian expressions of intimacy which kept the erotic and the spiritual entirely separate. In addition, attacks on the movement's 'effeminacy' were not directed against any visible homosexuality. In 1851, effeminacy did not necessarily denote homosexual desire. Attacks on the effeminacy and ritual of the Tractarians such as that by Kingsley were not specifically about gender, but instead included a cluster of fears about national identity, religious ethics, secrecy, manliness and the role of the church in the world.

Kingsley's attacks on celibacy were motivated by his particular view of marriage, nature and the role of the church. He belonged to a section of the church to which has been attached the somewhat pejorative label 'muscular Christianity'. This was a form of liberal Anglicanism which sought engagement with, and active intervention in, the problems of the world, and also rejected dogmatic distinctions between truth and error. As a result it set itself against the ethos of ascetic purity and withdrawal associated with Tractarianism. According to this view, it was celibacy rather than any more 'unnatural' passion that was the worst crime of Anglo-Catholicism because it alienated man from his natural self. As John Maynard has shown, Kingsley's enthusiastic embrace of marital sexuality, and the placing of sexual desire at the heart of his religious worldview, gave his assaults on the Tractarians a very personal edge. Kingsley, in common with the men and women written about by historians like Steven Seidman and Peter Gay, regarded marital sex as a religious and spiritual rite, a kind of 'communion' between husband and wife.¹⁹ Although, as Seidman argues, the spiritual was introduced to mitigate sensuality, it nevertheless took its place at the centre of Christian sexuality. For Christians like Kingsley, the spiritual and the sexual were not necessarily separate, but, Maynard suggests, were aspects of each other, mutually reinforcing modes of expression. Kingsley saw in Tractarianism the belief that man was an essentially spiritual, non-sexual being, and this contradicted his own view of the nature of humanity, the role of religion and the place of sexuality within it. Therefore, the controversy between Tractarians and evangelicals, Kingsley and Newman, was in fact sexual, but it was not only about effeminacy and possible homosexuality in the way earlier historians have assumed.

More recent approaches guided by queer theory offer a way through the thicket of argument about both the Oxford Movement and the nature of spiritual friendship. Queer approaches suggest that instead of trying to read homosexuality into past friendships, we should understand those

attachments on their own terms. On the one hand, queer interpretations simply compel us to be more careful with the sources, and not to foist modern categories of understanding on the past. On the other, queer theory recognizes that sexuality cannot necessarily be subsumed within categories like heterosexual/homosexual. As a result, queer approaches are profoundly historical in suggesting that we recognize the fundamental otherness of past sexual experience or desire. Frederick Roden, Ellis Hanson, and literary scholars such as David Alderson and Julia Savile therefore suggest that understanding the intimacies of men like Newman, Froude and Frederick Faber as profoundly indeterminate, as resistant to modern understandings of gender and desire, is a far more radical step to take than simply identifying them as homosexual using the interpretive terms of the present. As we have seen, when such identification is attempted, there is always some doubt, some extra multiplicity, something left over that the sources cannot recount. Roden, for instance, focuses not on sexual identity, but on 'an erotic energy that might be expressed as love, sublimated in friendship, used as the driving force for the creation of literary art, or embraced as religious ecstasy'.²⁰ The fundamental otherness of past sexuality must therefore be confronted.

As the Newman–Kingsley controversy shows, anti-Catholicism in British culture had a profoundly sexual element. Conflicts over the nature of Catholicism were also imported into the US because of the conflicting religious allegiances of immigrants from northern and southern Europe. One of the most pernicious aspects of Catholicism, according to its critics, was the fact that it made specific threats to morality and the family, especially through the practice of confession. Anti-Catholic agitators in Britain argued that the practice of confession was particularly threatening to women, since it involved a detailed interrogation about their secret sins which could extend to sexual matters. Fears about the apparent secrecy of Catholic practices extended not just to the confessional, but also to anxieties about what went on in Tractarian brotherhoods and Catholic convents. Walter Arnstein has described the career of one leading anti-Catholic Member of Parliament, Charles Newdegate, who continually demanded an inspectorate for nunneries and monasteries, while at the same time employing private detectives to try and discover salacious convent scandals.²¹

The sexual danger posed by Catholicism was the theme of much anti-Catholic writing on both sides of the Atlantic in the nineteenth century. As Hanson has pointed out, anti-Catholic writing frequently functions as the 'pornography of Puritanism', in the sense that it portrays Catholicism as inherently sexual: it is 'vampiric... seductive, perverse, decadent,

often feminine, and certainly fatal'.²² The sexual peril lurking in the confessional was the theme of the most famous anti-Catholic pamphlet in Victorian Britain. *The Confessional Unmasked: Showing the Depravity of the Romish Priesthood, the Iniquity of the Confessional and the Questions Put to Females in Confession*, was first published in Britain in 1836. It purported to expose the teaching of Catholic priests at the seminary in Maynooth, Ireland, which in the face of much controversy, was funded by the British government. The pamphlet consisted of extracts from eighteenth-century instruction manuals for priests, and focused particularly on questions about sexual sin. Some of these extracts governed 'the Carnal sins which man and wife commit with one another', and specified sinful sexual positions, while others dealt with 'Touches, Looks and Filthy Words' and the sin of Onan.²³ These instructions were said to pose a grievous threat to the virtue of women and the sanctity of the family. 'Are not these questions', the author asked,

Questions pressed by celibate priests on maids and married women – on British subjects and British legislators – in private and under terror of damnation *admirably* adapted, by their PIOUS OBSCENITY and RELIGIOUS MALICE, to convert an Eden into a Sodom, a hospitable people into fanatical assassins?²⁴

Whereas attacks on the Oxford Movement had been inexplicit in their assaults on effeminacy and 'sentimental' young men, anti-Catholic propaganda like *The Confessional Unmasked* used language specifically designed to inflame sexual terrors and associate sexual depravity with Catholics and Irish immigrants. 'Romish priests', it declared, were trapped in the contradiction of their faith. They were supposed to be moral but confession demanded that they traffic in intimate and indecent sexual knowledge. As a consequence, a priest was both 'pure as an angel, yet more corrupt than a Sodomite... the slave of the most debasing sensuality', guilty of 'exposing the nakedness and perverting the faculties of those who put themselves under his influence'.²⁵ Women were especially at risk from these 'mesmerists', who would usurp the authority of fathers if allowed. A lecture tour to publicize the book drew supporters and opponents in vast numbers to British cities, with as many as 100,000 people gathering in Birmingham in 1867 in support of or in opposition to the lecturer Patrick Murphy. Wherever he went across the north and midlands of England, 'Murphy riots' broke out. Sexual matters, in this case, were at the very centre of Victorian questions of religion, race and immigration.

The example of the *Confessional Unmasked*, as well as the Kingsley–Newman controversy, shows that there were moments in the nineteenth century when sexual matters did become linked explicitly with questions of religion and spirituality. In addition, towards the end of the century there was a noticeable turn among homosexual writers towards religion. Hilliard's work suggests that in the late nineteenth century the homoeroticism which was always present in the spiritual friendships established in Anglo-Catholic monasteries became far more explicit and open. Ellis Hanson also maintains that many decadent writers, including Walter Pater and Oscar Wilde, turned to Catholicism in the 1890s because of its similarity to aspects of aestheticism. Moreover, a number of writers turned to ideas of spiritual comradeship to argue for the legitimacy of homosexual desire, and to take a stand against late-Victorian discourses which identified that desire as low, brutal and wholly physical.

The moment when the language of spiritual love and attachment changed, and became openly available to describe sexual, and specifically, homoerotic desire, can be glimpsed in the 1890s. The language of comradeship was one of the key resources of English writers like Edward Carpenter and John Addington Symonds, two of the most famous homophile authors of the late nineteenth century. Both argued tentatively for the nobility of homosexual desire against the prevailing view that it was a species of moral wickedness. A key element in this reformulation of comradeship was the poetry of Walt Whitman. Whitman's work was a celebration of the working man, of 'comrade love', and the beauty of the physical body. Symonds in particular found in Whitman the perfect unity of spirit, body and love, a trinity which had the potential to ennoble all attachments between men. In addition, this 'democratic chivalry' promised to help bridge the distance between the classes. Whitman's writing was not only a vision of manly love, but also provided an account of how comradeship could cement a progressive social movement based on love that would build a new Jerusalem – a 'City of Friends'. Whitman promised to 'make the most splendid race the sun every yet shone upon', to 'Make divine magnetic lands/ With the love of comrades,/ With the life-long love of comrades'.²⁶

Whitman's idea of comrade love always contained something ineffable and spiritual, 'something fierce and terrible in me, eligible to burst forth, I dare not tell it, even in these songs'. This ineffability lent itself to spiritual and homoerotic readings, especially of the 'Calamus' sections of *Leaves of Grass*. The spiritual or the transcendent was vital to Whitman, as it was to his followers in Britain, Europe and North America. As modern critics have noted, Whitman equates desire and death. For him, death is

a means of transcending the spiritual and bodily agonies brought about by an intense passion:

O I think it is not for life I am chanting here my chant of lovers, I think it must be for death,
For how calm, how solemn it grows to ascend to the atmosphere of lovers,
Death or life I am then indifferent, my soul declines to prefer
(I am not sure but the high soul of lovers welcomes death most)²⁷

Such visions of transcendent love provided a common theme in the writing of the 1890s, especially in attempts to legitimize homosexuality. In particular, the ineffable nature of Whitman's poetry, his equation of death, desire and spiritual love proved useful to those men who sought to escape the supposed 'morbidity' of homoerotic desire by insisting on its transcendent quality.²⁸ In the writing of the *fin de siècle* we can see the language of chivalry, and spiritual comradeship turning tentatively into an explicit vocabulary of sexual desire.

This is particularly visible among the followers of Whitman and Carpenter, although it is by no means confined to them. The remarkable diaries of a Scottish doctor give some clue as to how the ideas of spirituality, comradeship, homoerotic desire and transcendent spiritual love coalesced. John Johnston, who lived in Bolton in the northwest of England, belonged to a small group of friends who knew Edward Carpenter and informed his theories of the 'intermediate sex'. Johnston and his confreres also took a keen interest in many contemporary movements and intellectual trends, including socialism, Whitman, theories of homosexuality, theosophy and spiritualism. In spite of having little connection with literary circles, they met Walt Whitman and tried, with some success, to use his 'teachings' on the nature of comradeship to influence the early Labour party. The significance of these men lies in the way they used spirituality as a resource to understand their desire.

Johnston and his friend J.W. Wallace habitually expressed an effusive, romantic love for each other, and both borrowed ideas from Carpenter and Whitman to examine their own desires. They exalted comrade love, and found its pure expression in Whitman's poetry, but they also began to entertain the idea that a new type of person was evolving who would develop what they called 'cosmic consciousness'. This mystical new form of awareness was, they thought, evident in Whitman, and to an extent in Carpenter. It involved the sudden development of a higher awareness, an experience akin to both religious conversion and sexual awakening.

Undergoing such a revelation gave one a realization of the oneness of the universe, and heralded the development of acute powers of perception. One of the signs of cosmic consciousness was the ability to develop a transcendent love for one's comrades. Both Wallace and Johnston fell under the spell of a young American Whitmanite named Philip Dalmas, a man who seemed to have developed cosmic consciousness. In his case this was expressed in an extravagant, sometimes physical love which he assured Johnston would endure after death, in synaesthesia and various other manifestations of acute psychical development including the self-professed development of an 'astral body'.

The idea of cosmic consciousness, which was originally developed by Whitman's doctor R.M. Bucke, influenced Edward Carpenter in his attempt to describe homosexual or 'intermediate' types of people. Carpenter argued that men and women who experienced homosexual desire combined the characteristics of both sexes. As a result, they tended to have the beneficial features of both masculinity and femininity, and to represent a higher stage in evolution. Such 'higher' types, like Walt Whitman or Philip Dalmas could be seen infrequently in the world already. On a more mundane level, the invert who had not attained quite such a high state of consciousness would nevertheless typically have a talent for art, music and social reform.²⁹

The experiences of men like Johnston and Dalmas therefore reinforced Carpenter's theories. As Joy Dixon and Andrew Elfenbein have pointed out, these ideas had partly emerged from continental anthropology, and had a strong influence on early sexual science.³⁰ Carpenter's travels in Ceylon and India, as well as his reading of anthropology, provided ample evidence that in 'primitive' societies priests and shamen frequently took on female roles, lived as wives to men, and were in fact 'intermediate types'. This realization, along with the astonishing personality of men like Philip Dalmas, seemed to confirm Carpenter's suggestions.

Far from being an isolated and unconsidered idea, the association between higher perception, advanced evolutionary stages and homosexuality informed a number of different discourses. Joy Dixon points out that Havelock Ellis' pioneering work of sexology, *Studies in the Psychology of Sex*, incorporated Carpenter's insights and included case studies of homosexual men who felt themselves to have developed the same advanced psychic and intellectual qualities that he and others had identified as characteristic of the invert. Whereas a previous generation of historians have stressed the medical and scientific aspects of sexology in making homosexual identity in this period, it is much more accurate to see sexual science as informed by a variety of progressive discourses, one

of which was this spiritual-evolutionary understanding of the self. Andrew Elfenbein has argued that the association of special gifts with androgyny and even sexual transgression was also a much older idea, dating back to the Romanticism of the late eighteenth century. Lord Byron was the most significant figure in this idea of the sexually transgressive, queer romantic genius. His work, Elfenbein argues, cemented 'an association between genius and mysteriously unfathomable depths of erotic transgression'.³¹ The idea of the specially gifted homosexual continued to have vitality well into the twentieth century.

In addition to these associations, other, less radical writers sought to use ideas of 'higher consciousness' to rethink the nature of same-sex desire. In Germany, the idea of the homosexual as a super-masculine type and a more highly evolved individual caught on much more widely than in Britain.³² There, homosexual desire was claimed by homophile writers to be merely an extension of masculine association, or *mannerbund*. Other discourses used the idea of a higher self to present a more pacific and respectable face to the world. The French émigré and aesthete Marc Andre Raffalovich, for example, sought to make sexual inversion palatable to society by denuding it of its erotic content. The 'higher' invert was capable, according to him, of developing a spiritual being that could sublimate sexual desire through art, religion and friendship, unlike the lower pervert/sodomite who was defined solely by his passion for sex. Other aesthetic writers, such as the poet John Gray, embraced religion to escape their decadence and sexuality. Hanson points out that writers like Raffalovich and Gray were going against the trend of the times. Instead of using the spiritual as a resource for erotic desire, they were using religion and the idea of higher consciousness to put eroticism back in its place.³³

The idea that the self might harbour another kind of consciousness, whether higher or lower, was a prevalent idea in the last two decades of the nineteenth century, especially among spiritualists. As I will explain, spiritualism also had strong links with gender transgression and unconventional sexuality. It originated in the northeastern United States, an area which was visited repeatedly by millenarian religious revivals before 1850, and which also produced the communitarian experiments discussed earlier. In this turbid atmosphere two young sisters in Rochester, New York claimed to have heard unearthly knockings and to have talked to the spirits. These 'Rochester rappings' became a national sensation and the craze for spiritualism soon spread to Britain where it became most popular in places where nonconformist Protestant sects and freethinking movements such as Owenite socialism had thrived. Alex Owen divides

the spiritualist movement into three phases. The first evolved from the 1850s onwards, when spiritualism became immensely popular among the working classes, partly because of its strong association with radical politics. By the 1870s, a number of young, working-class women had become famous as mediums. However, by the late 1880s many of these women had been exposed as fraudulent or had confessed their imposture. After that, the focus of spiritualism turned away from mediumistic manifestations to scientific investigation of trance states, dreams, telepathy and automatic writing under the auspices of the educated intellectuals who led the Society for Psychical Research (SPR).

Alex Owen's classic work on spiritualism and gender, *The Darkened Room*, shows how spiritualism, like earlier religions of enthusiasm and millennial socialism, provided a space in which gender and sexuality could be transgressed safely. An indication of this status was that free love, women's rights, and other radical causes were often espoused by the same people who embraced spiritualism. Moreover, Owen points out that mediumship was a means for ordinarily powerless young women to assume status and celebrity, make a living, and gain social cachet by mixing with higher classes. In addition, the darkened room of the séance was a place where the normal rules of morality and decorum were suspended. Physical intimacy such as holding hands around the table was usual, while mediums and 'spirits' would often caress the sitters, kiss them or sit in their laps. The séance was, Owen argues, a kind of arena for the play of the unconscious, a place for the acting out of unconventional and uncanny desires. The séance was, to use a more recent theoretical idiom, queer. By focusing on physical manifestations of all kinds, Owen says, it disclosed 'the polymorphous, paradoxical, deviant, erratic, eccentric, even scandalous nature of desire and its enactment'.³⁴

But was Psychical Research queer in a more obvious way? Did it provide a useful location for homosexual men and women to investigate alternative selves? Roger Luckhurst has certainly shown that what were earlier regarded as intimate, spiritual friendships were often rethought in the 1880s and 1890s as a kind of telepathic relation.³⁵ Some of the SPR leaders were homosexual, and this reinforces the impression that spirituality, 'higher' or 'alternate' states of mind and body, which were the dominating preoccupation of many late-Victorian homosexuals, and which later became central to self-making and to modern culture in general, have been largely overlooked by historians of sexuality. These ideas also have a much wider historical relevance. What we now consider supremely modern, secular ideas and discourses, were informed at crucial points by ideas like spiritualism and psychical research. The beginnings

of modern psychiatry, psychoanalysis and psychology had their origins in research into the dynamic unconscious mind carried out by the SPR and its associates.³⁶

The association between research into an alternate self and same-sex desire is by no means coincidental. Searching for a higher self which might be the source and location of homoerotic desire should not be seen as a form of repression. Instead, spiritualism, Whitmanite spirituality, Anglo-Catholic aestheticism and mediumship might all enable the expression of awkward passions which in other locations were regarded as at best immoral and at worst unnatural. Therefore it is relevant to a history of homosexual identity that some of the principal figures in the SPR were homosexual, including its leading researchers Frederick Myers, Frank Podmore and others. Myers had been at Cambridge with the homosexual and Whitmanite writer John Addington Symonds, and had also been interested in Whitman's poetry and Hellenism, although he later married.³⁷ The death of another SPR researcher, Edmund Gurney, in 1888 was also rumoured to have been suicide in anticipation of homosexual blackmail and consequent exposure. Gurney and Podmore had taken rooms in Brighton to conduct experiments in telepathy with a local stage hypnotist who claimed to be able to read minds. The subjects of these experiments at length confessed themselves fraudulent, and, according to one theory, Gurney's despair at the ruin of his life's work led him to suicide.³⁸

Does Gurney's death or possible suicide show that there was a homosexual element to SPR researches? Gurney was working closely with Frank Podmore, who, in addition to his efforts for the SPR, worked for the Post Office in London. The office in which Podmore worked in St Martin's Lane became notorious in 1889 when the Cleveland Street scandal revealed that telegraph messengers from that office had been entertaining members of the aristocracy in a male brothel in the West End of London. Long before the scandal broke, telegraph boys had been notorious for their willingness to have sex with men for money, a fact of which Podmore must have been aware.³⁹ This fact makes it all the more surprising that Gurney and Podmore were prepared to lock themselves away in a Brighton hotel with a number of working-class youths, including several telegraph messengers, in order to conduct intimate experiments into their states of mind.

The association between 'higher' states or selves, psychical research and unconventional sexuality persisted in the twentieth century, and informed the emergence of another predominantly secular creed: literary and cultural modernism. Richard Dellamora has suggested that

early modernism was marked strongly by its association with same-sex desire. Moreover, the decentring of consciousness, and the play with conventional gender roles which was so central to the work of Edward Carpenter, to the Whitmanites, and to many leading spiritualists, were later the stock in trade of modernist writers.⁴⁰ The British pacifist novel *Despised and Rejected* (1918), the hero of which is a classic type of the 'higher' invert in combining the best characteristics of either sex, was clearly inspired by the work of Edward Carpenter.⁴¹

More famous modernists also belonged to this tradition. Andrew Elfenbein has identified this trend in Radclyffe Hall's classic novel of lesbian self-discovery, *The Well of Loneliness* (1928). As well as being an enthusiastic Catholic, Hall herself was keenly interested in spiritualism, not only visiting a medium to contact her former lover Mabel Batten, but also publishing a paper with the SPR on the subject. The protagonist of the *Well*, the mannish lesbian 'Stephen' Gordon, is also a mixture of the higher invert, the classic sexological case study, and the 'intermediate type'. As Elfenbein points out, Stephen is a kind of genius who embodies masculine and feminine characteristics, and is also a classic type of invert who believes that her 'fine brain' and superior consciousness should be recognized as useful by society.⁴²

However, in spite of its queer beginnings, twentieth-century modernism was more usually defined by its rejection of same-sex desire and its preference for hard facts over spiritual speculations. In this sense it reflected a general de-coupling of the link between religion-spirituality and sexuality which has gone on apace in the last hundred years. After sexology and psychoanalysis it became harder to argue that religious enthusiasm or spiritual comradeship did not have a primarily sexual origin, especially since Carpenter, Whitman and others had shown that this might be the case. By 1918, in wartime America, even the very idea of Christian brotherhood had to be defended against allegations that it was inherently homoerotic.⁴³ Whereas nineteenth-century religion had been allowed to be truly queer, in the sense that its cultural prestige and immense social authority meant that it might cover a variety of polymorphous and unspecific transgressions of gender and sexuality, by the early twentieth century religion had come under suspicion and fallen into decay as one of the principal locations for sexual expression of all kinds. Exceptions to this rule existed, not least in the form of Marie Stopes, whose best-selling writings on birth control and marital sex continued to characterize heterosexual sex as a mystical and ineffable communion.⁴⁴

In spite of the persistence of this mystical idiom in the writings of Stopes, the place of religion in discussions of sexuality became

increasingly insignificant. After the First World War, many modernist writers became increasingly impatient with the professed religious motivations of their eminent Victorian predecessors, and saw in their careers not the pure love of God but a self-serving hypocrisy. Progressive writers on sexuality also began to attack the entire structure of Western morals which had produced the catastrophe of war and what they saw as widespread ignorance about the facts of life. According to the advocates of wider sex education, religious morals were one of the key obstacles to sexual knowledge and were the mainstay of prudery and ignorance. This association was cemented by the religious origins of many social purity organizations in Britain, America and Western Europe.

Until the beginning of the twentieth century, spirituality reigned supreme as the desired ingredient of all passionate intimacy, including sexual desire. Since then, the spiritual element of sexual passion has lost its eminence along with the declining status of religion in Western societies as a whole. In much of Western Europe, the church, faith and the spirit no longer occupy a central role in the guidance of married couples, romantic friends, gay or straight men and women. Although the rise of the religious right in the US since the 1970s has provided a powerful challenge to liberal ideals and reforms from sex education to gay partnership laws, this evangelical zeal remains a localized American phenomenon. In spite of calls by evangelical Christians for new, more restrictive moral codes, it remains the case that in America religious discourses have not displaced medical or therapeutic versions of sexuality. Psychotherapy in all its forms, but most obviously in the shape of popular guides to relationships whose nostrums are reflected in TV, radio, novels, magazines and across the culture as a whole, remains largely unchallenged by fundamentalist Christianity. In fact, it is a measure of the dominance of the therapeutic model of selfhood that evangelical Christianity tries repeatedly to merge its own language with that of popular psychotherapy.

The fact that psychotherapeutic discourses are so dominant in European and American societies provides a good reason to study spiritual passion and religious sexuality. One of the main differences between past and existing structures of sexuality and intimacy is their spiritual content. This fact allows us to examine the fundamental otherness of sexual desire and the self even in the immediate past. Incidents such as the Newman–Kingsley controversy, the history of American communitarianism, or the nature of spiritual romantic friendship shows us that sexual desire cannot be reduced simply to the categories which are currently employed. Studies of this sort lend themselves very well to queer readings of the past. Insofar as queer refers to kinds of sexual expression which exceed

available categories of gender and sexuality, the study of spirituality and sexuality is an eminently queer project.

notes

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